



A former French colony, Mali is landlocked in the heart of west Africa. The 1991 coup ended the 23-year dictatorship of Moussa Traoré and ushered in multiparty elections from 1992.



GEOGRAPHY

The northern half of the country lies in the Sahara. The inland delta of the Niger River flows through a grassy savanna region in the south.



CLIMATE

In the south, intensely hot, dry weather precedes the westerly rains. The north is almost rainless.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most people live in the southern savanna region. The Bambara tribe are culturally and politically dominant. A few nomadic Fulani and Tuareg herders travel the northern plains. There is tension between the peoples of the south and Tuareg in the north. Malian women have little status.



INSIGHT: *Tombouctou (Timbuktu) was the center of the 14th-century*

Malinké trading empire



THE ECONOMY

Widespread poverty. Most people are farmers, herders, or river fishermen. Less than 2% of land can be cultivated. High-quality cotton, gold, and livestock account for 80% of exports. Vulnerable to drought.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Mali

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Bamako

POPULATION: 13 million

TOTAL AREA: 478,764 sq. miles
(1,240,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 28 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Bambara, Fulani, Senufo, Soninke, French*

RELIGIONS: Muslim 80%, traditional beliefs 18%, Christian 1%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Bambara 32%, other 33%, Fulani 14%, Senufu 12%, Soninka 9%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes